

Lopat Sells Coates On Yankee School

By ANDY McCUTCHEON

Virginians manager Ed Lopat, doing unto others as he would have others do unto him, contributed a good turn for the New York Yankees while here for the annual mid-winter baseball dinner.

Before making a public pitch for Yankee help to principal speaker Jerry Coleman last night at the Hotel John Marshall, Lopat put in a call to Jim Coates, a 14-game winner for the Virginians last season.

HAD BALKED

Coates had balked at reporting to the Yankees' acceleration school in St. Petersburg next month. Expenses are paid but not salaries. Lopat convinced Coates the financial aspect was secondary to his opportunity with the Yankees.

Lopat's request for help from Coleman, now an assistant to Yankee personnel director Lee MacPhail, came in the form of a threat—"come up with some infielders or be drafted to play for us."

Lopat expected the threat

to carry some weight. Despite more than 50 missions with the U. S. Marine Corps in both World War II and the Korean conflict as a pilot, Coleman is not fond of flying.

"In this (International) league," warned Lopat, "you spend about half your time in the air."

Managing, money and the promises of Yankee help came in for a round of debunking last night as 697 fans saw toastmaster Lefty Gomez carry the two-hour program on his broad and funny shoulders.

11 STRAIGHT

Managers, said Gomez, are overrated. "I managed an all-native team in Caracas, Venezuela. I couldn't understand them, they couldn't understand me and we finished one-half game out of first place.

"In Havana," he added, "I managed a team only half-native. Half the players could understand me and we finished fifth. In Binghamton, N. Y., all the players could understand me and we finished last.

"We lost 11 in a row with

that Binghamton team," said Gomez, "and the next night we were rained out. I threw a victory party."

E. Claiborne Robins, president of the Virginians, took the money angle. "Bear in mind," he said, "that a blank check doesn't buy a team. But we are going to do everything possible to have a good team."

Gomez re-entered the debunking act after listening to Lopat's thoughts on the players expected to be directed this way by the parent Yankees, who work with the Virginians.

"I was in Denver (another Yankee triple-A farm) the other day," said Gomez, "and I heard the manager there, Andy Cohen, tell his fans he was getting these same players.

"All these Yankee prospects," he quipped, "must be twins."

BANQUET BITS—Coleman pin-pointed the scouting system as the key factor in the Yankees' success. Beyond talent, he said, the scouts are looking for the boy "with the head, heart and desire" . . . Virginians general manager Herman Kratten-